

BBA II SEMESTER

GENERAL ENGLISH (Edify II)

IMPORTANT QUESTIONS & ANSWERS

Bengaluru City University — Faculty of Management
Covers ALL Topics | Literature + Language Components

Course	L2 — General English
Credits	3 Internal: 20 Marks External: 80 Marks
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SECTION A — LITERARY COMPONENTS

LESSON 1 — NEXT, PLEASE

Poem by Philip Larkin

Part I — Short Answer Questions (1 Mark Each)

Q1. What is the central metaphor used in the poem?

[1 Mark]

Ans: The ships represent human desires and expectations.

Q2. What is the tone of the poem 'Next, Please'?

[1 Mark]

Ans: The tone is contemplative, regretful, and pessimistic.

Q3. What does the 'black-sailed ship' represent?

[1 Mark]

Ans: It represents death — the one certainty that eventually arrives for everyone.

Q4. What does the 'sparkling armada of promises' symbolize?

[1 Mark]

Ans: It symbolizes the fleeting and often unattainable hopes and dreams of human beings.

Q5. What does Larkin suggest about human expectations?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Larkin suggests that human expectations are often unfulfilled and lead to disappointment.

Q6. What is the fate of the ships in the poem?

[1 Mark]

Ans: The ships vanish or fail to deliver, symbolizing unfulfilled expectations.

Q7. What is the only ship that actually arrives according to Larkin?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Death — it is the only certain thing that comes to every person.

Part II — Medium Answer Questions (5 Marks Each)

Q8. How does Larkin use the metaphor of ships to comment on human expectations?

[5 Marks]

Ans: In 'Next, Please', Philip Larkin uses ships as a powerful metaphor for human hopes and promises. The ships represent desired futures that seem to approach but never fully arrive. Each ship carries expectations of fulfillment, yet they consistently disappoint or vanish. This metaphor illustrates how humans are always looking forward to the 'next' promise—the next success, next happiness, next reward—but these desires remain perpetually out of reach. The endless sea mirrors the vastness of

human longing, while the disappearing ships reflect the futility of that longing. Larkin shows that anticipation itself becomes the human condition, with the only certain arrival being death.

Q9. Discuss the significance of time in the poem 'Next, Please'.

[5 Marks]

Ans: Time is a critical and elusive element in 'Next, Please'. Larkin portrays time as something that constantly moves forward while humans remain fixed in anticipation. Instead of cherishing the present, people are always focused on what is to come—the next moment, the next promise. This obsession with future time comes at the cost of truly living in the present. The poem suggests that our entire lives can be consumed in waiting, and this waiting ultimately leads only to death. Time, therefore, is both a source of hope and the very thing that reveals the futility of that hope.

Q10. What role does the setting of the poem play in conveying the poet's message?

[5 Marks]

Ans: The sea setting in 'Next, Please' is deeply symbolic. The vast, infinite ocean represents the ungraspable nature of human hope—always stretching to a horizon that can never be reached. Ships coming across the sea mirror the constant anticipation of something greater. The endless expanse amplifies the sense of futility: no matter how many ships appear on the horizon, none brings lasting fulfillment. The setting thus reinforces Larkin's central message that human desire for a better future is as boundless and unachievable as the sea itself.

Part III — Long Answer Questions (10 Marks Each)

Q11. In what ways does 'Next, Please' reflect Larkin's broader poetic concerns such as the search for meaning, inevitability of disappointment, and death?

[10 Marks]

Ans: Philip Larkin's 'Next, Please' encapsulates his recurring poetic preoccupations. First, the search for meaning: the poem critiques humanity's constant quest for fulfillment through future promises, suggesting that no ultimate meaning can be found in anticipation. Second, the inevitability of disappointment: every ship that appears on the horizon—every hope, every ambition—either vanishes or fails to deliver what was promised. This consistent disappointment is not accidental but structural; Larkin implies it is built into the human condition. Third, the inevitability of death: the 'black-sailed ship' that finally arrives is death itself. Larkin contrasts the illusory, colorful armada of promises with this single, certain, dark vessel. The poem thus becomes a meditation on mortality—a reminder that in all our waiting for the 'next' good thing, we are really waiting for death. Larkin's characteristic pessimism is evident throughout, as he refuses to offer comfort or resolution, instead presenting a stark, unblinking view of what it means to be human: to hope, to be disappointed, and to die.

LESSON 2 — NINE GOLD MEDALS

Poem by David Roth

Part I — Short Answer Questions (1 Mark Each)

Q1. What caused the nine athletes to stop running?

[1 Mark]

Ans: One of the athletes stumbled and fell, and the other eight stopped to help.

Q2. What is the main theme of 'Nine Gold Medals'?

[1 Mark]

Ans: The values of cooperation, empathy, and compassion over individual competition.

Q3. What does 'Special Olympics' refer to in the poem?

[1 Mark]

Ans: An international athletic event for athletes with special needs.

Q4. What does the standing ovation symbolize?

[1 Mark]

Ans: It symbolizes the crowd's recognition of the athletes' extraordinary compassion and sportsmanship.

Q5. What is implied by the 'nine gold medals'?

[1 Mark]

Ans: They represent the value of sportsmanship, human kindness, and collective triumph over individual glory.

Q6. What emotion does the poet evoke when describing the runners' actions?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Empathy, kindness, and deep admiration for human solidarity.

Part II — Medium Answer Questions (5 Marks Each)

Q7. How does the poet present the importance of human values over competition in the poem?

[5 Marks]

Ans: David Roth beautifully illustrates that human values transcend competitive achievement. When one runner falls, the others abandon the race entirely—sacrificing their chance at victory—to help a fellow competitor. This selfless act transforms a competitive event into a celebration of empathy. The poet emphasizes that the athletes' choice to support rather than surpass each other represents a higher form of victory. The gold medals they each receive symbolize not athletic speed, but moral excellence. Through this narrative, Roth argues that the measure of a person—or a society—lies not in how fast we run, but in how willingly we stop to help those who fall.

Q8. Discuss the significance of the title 'Nine Gold Medals'.

[5 Marks]

Ans: The title is deeply symbolic. Traditionally, gold medals are awarded to winners of competitions—to the fastest or the best. In this poem, however, all nine athletes receive gold medals not for winning a race, but for demonstrating extraordinary humanity. The title thus redefines what 'winning' means: it is not about individual speed or strength, but about collective compassion and the willingness to put another's need above one's own glory. The nine medals represent nine acts of kindness, nine moments of choosing unity over victory. The title challenges conventional ideas of success in sports and in life.

Part III — Long Answer Questions (10 Marks Each)

Q9. How does the poem challenge traditional ideas of winning and success? Explore the theme of empathy in detail.

[10 Marks]

Ans: David Roth's 'Nine Gold Medals' fundamentally challenges the traditional sporting idea that winning means crossing the finish line first. In conventional sports, the strongest, fastest individual is celebrated, and others' struggles are irrelevant to that pursuit of victory. The poem dismantles this notion entirely. When one athlete falls, the natural competitive instinct would be to continue running and seize advantage. Instead, all eight remaining athletes stop, return to the fallen runner, and together walk across the finish line. This act elevates empathy above ambition. The theme of empathy runs throughout the poem with great depth. Empathy here is not passive sympathy—it is active, costly, and sacrificial. Each athlete genuinely risks their own medal, their own glory, to ensure no one is left behind. This portrayal of empathy suggests that true human connection is more valuable than any trophy. The poem also challenges society's obsession with individual achievement. In a world that prizes personal success, the athletes' collective action is a radical statement: that community, compassion, and care for others are the highest human achievements. The gold medals they receive serve as a metaphor—the greatest prize is not won by running the fastest, but by choosing to run together, or not at all, for the sake of another.

LESSON 3 — THE BROKER

Short Story by Ram Swaroop Kisan

Part I — Short Answer Questions (1 Mark Each)

Q1. Who is Tansukh?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Tansukh is a broker in a village who acts as a middleman helping people buy and sell goods, especially livestock.

Q2. Why was Tansukh highly regarded in his village?

[1 Mark]

Ans: He was regarded for his sharp negotiating skills and ability to make reliable deals between buyers and sellers.

Q3. Why couldn't Tansukh sleep?

[1 Mark]

Ans: He was troubled by a moral dilemma—wanting to help both Kashi Regar's wife and the old man's son, which was not possible simultaneously.

Q4. What does the symbolism of sparrows quarrelling represent at the end?

[1 Mark]

Ans: The sparrows symbolize the ongoing, bitter conflicts and desperate competition in human life.

Q5. Why was Kashi desperate to sell his buffalo?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Kashi needed money urgently to feed his family and pay off his debts.

Q6. Who are the 'two hungry figures' stretching their hands toward Tansukh?

[1 Mark]

Ans: They are Kashi Regar's wife and the old man's son, symbolizing the desperate need of the poor.

Part II — Medium Answer Questions (5 Marks Each)

Q7. Analyse the character of Tansukh in the backdrop of his struggle for livelihood.

[5 Marks]

Ans: Tansukh is a morally complex character shaped by poverty and circumstance. Professionally, he is skilled, efficient, and respected as a broker. However, his livelihood depends on exploiting the desperation of others—buying low, selling high, and profiting from the vulnerability of people like Kashi and the old man. Yet Tansukh is not entirely hardened. His sleeplessness reflects a conscience that has not been completely eroded by poverty's dehumanizing pressures. He genuinely wants to help both parties but is caught in a system that does not allow for purely charitable solutions. His internal conflict shows that even those complicit in corrupt systems may retain their humanity, making him a powerful symbol of how poverty forces moral compromises.

Q8. What thoughts occupy Tansukh's mind as he rests on his charpai?

[5 Marks]

Ans: As Tansukh rests, he is consumed by his moral dilemma. He thinks about Kashi Regar's desperate need to sell the buffalo and the old man's equally desperate need to buy one. He wonders how he can serve both parties fairly. He reflects on the ethics of his profession—whether profiting from human suffering is justifiable. The decayed thatch above him reminds him of the precariousness of his own life. He questions whether there is a more honourable path, revealing that beneath his practical exterior lies a man troubled by the moral cost of survival.

Part III — Long Answer Questions (10 Marks Each)

Q9. Comment on the themes of corruption, exploitation, and moral degradation in 'The Broker'.

[10 Marks]

Ans: Ram Swaroop Kisan's 'The Broker' is a powerful critique of systemic corruption and its human cost. The story centres on Tansukh, whose profession as a broker places him at the intersection of exploitation and survival. Corruption in the story is not dramatic or visible—it is quiet, everyday, and normalized. Tansukh does not take bribes from government officials; he simply profits from the misfortune of poor villagers who have no alternative. This subtlety makes the corruption more disturbing. Exploitation is depicted through both Kashi Regar and the old man. Both are financially desperate and must rely on Tansukh, who has the power to dictate the terms of their transactions. The broker system itself is exploitative—middlemen gain while both buyers and sellers often lose. Moral degradation is shown through Tansukh's inner conflict. He recognizes the injustice of his position but cannot escape it. Poverty has eroded his ability to act according to his conscience. The unfinished statement 'I am...' at the story's end perfectly captures this degradation: Tansukh cannot define himself because his identity has been compromised by the system he serves. Kisan uses Tansukh not to condemn an individual but to indict a society that creates and sustains such figures, forcing good people into morally ambiguous roles for survival.

LESSON 4 — THE LUNCHEON

Short Story by W. Somerset Maugham

Part I — Short Answer Questions (1 Mark Each)

Q1. Who is the narrator of 'The Luncheon'?

[1 Mark]

Ans: A young, financially struggling writer who recalls the incident from his past.

Q2. What is the main setting of the story?

[1 Mark]

Ans: An expensive, fashionable restaurant in Paris.

Q3. What did the woman claim she would eat?

[1 Mark]

Ans: She claimed she ate very little—only a light, modest meal.

Q4. What did she actually order?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Salmon, caviar, champagne, and other expensive items, contradicting her claims of modesty.

Q5. What is the central irony of the story?

[1 Mark]

Ans: The woman who claimed to eat lightly ordered the most expensive dishes, draining the narrator's limited budget.

Q6. What is the narrator's final revenge, described with humour?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Years later, the woman who claimed to eat lightly had become very overweight—nature's ironic justice.

Part II — Medium Answer Questions (5 Marks Each)

Q7. Discuss the use of irony in 'The Luncheon'.

[5 Marks]

Ans: Irony is the central device in 'The Luncheon'. The story's premise itself is ironic: a woman who insists she eats almost nothing proceeds to consume an elaborate and expensive feast. Her words ('I never eat more than one thing for luncheon') completely contradict her actions. The situational irony builds steadily as each course arrives, each more extravagant than the last. The narrator's growing anxiety, juxtaposed with the woman's cheerful obliviousness, creates rich dramatic irony—the reader understands the narrator's financial distress while the woman remains blissfully unaware. The final irony, delivered years later, is that the woman who prided herself on her delicate appetite became enormously overweight—a fitting, humorous conclusion that Maugham uses to suggest that such self-deception carries its own consequences.

Q8. Examine the theme of social class and pretence in 'The Luncheon'.

[5 Marks]

Ans: Maugham uses 'The Luncheon' to expose the pretences associated with social class. The woman uses the veneer of sophistication and modesty to manipulate a younger, less experienced man. Her choice of an expensive Paris restaurant signals her sense of social superiority, while her ordering of lavish dishes without concern for the narrator's budget reflects the entitlement of those who believe their class exempts them from financial consideration. The narrator, representing a lower social position, is trapped by politeness and the social expectation of generosity. He cannot challenge her without appearing rude or inferior. Maugham thus shows how social hierarchies create power imbalances in everyday interactions, allowing the privileged to exploit the less privileged through the unspoken rules of etiquette.

Part III — Long Answer Questions (10 Marks Each)

Q9. How does the author use setting, irony, and social dynamics to create both humour and critique in 'The Luncheon'?

[10 Marks]

Ans: Somerset Maugham masterfully combines setting, irony, and social observation to create a story that is simultaneously comic and critical. The setting—an expensive Parisian restaurant—immediately establishes a contrast between the narrator's modest means and the social world the woman inhabits. The grandeur of the restaurant is a visual metaphor for the social pressure the narrator faces; he cannot behave as he would in his own financial reality because the setting demands otherwise. Irony operates on multiple levels. There is verbal irony in the woman's repeated claims of modest eating while ordering extravagantly. There is situational irony in the narrator's politeness masking his growing financial panic. And there is dramatic irony in that the reader can see the manipulation the narrator cannot bring himself to name. Maugham uses these layers of irony to create humour, but beneath the comedy lies a sharp social critique. The story exposes how social conventions—politeness, deference to social superiors, fear of embarrassment—can be weaponized by those with higher status to exploit those below them. The woman faces no consequences in the moment; only time delivers justice. The humour in the ending (her eventual weight gain) provides catharsis for the narrator and reader alike, but Maugham's deeper point remains: social pretence is a form of dishonesty, and those who perform it do so at others' expense.

LESSON 5 — A SERVICE OF LOVE

Short Story by O. Henry

Part I — Short Answer Questions (1 Mark Each)

Q1. How did Joe and Delia meet?

[1 Mark]

Ans: They met while studying under the same art teacher in New York City.

Q2. What was Joe's artistic ambition?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Joe aspired to be a recognized painter.

Q3. What secret job did Delia take up?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Delia secretly worked as a laundress while pretending to give piano lessons.

Q4. What was Joe's secret job?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Joe secretly painted advertisements in a studio while claiming to sell his artwork.

Q5. How was their deception revealed?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Delia burned her hand while ironing clothes, which exposed the truth about her real job.

Q6. What is the significance of the title 'A Service of Love'?

[1 Mark]

Ans: It refers to the selfless acts of sacrifice both Joe and Delia perform out of love for each other.

Q7. Who was Clementina?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Clementina was the fictional piano student Delia invented as part of her cover story.

Part II — Medium Answer Questions (5 Marks Each)

Q8. How do Joe and Delia demonstrate their love through sacrifice in the story?

[5 Marks]

Ans: O. Henry presents love not as a romantic ideal but as a practical, self-denying commitment. Both Joe and Delia abandon their artistic dreams—their deepest passions—to ensure they can support their shared life. Joe gives up painting for commercial art work; Delia gives up music teaching for manual labour. Each hides the truth to protect the other from worry, choosing their partner's peace of mind over their own pride. These sacrifices are not dramatic gestures but quiet, daily acts of devotion. O. Henry thus argues that the truest expression of love is not in grand declarations but in unglamorous service and selfless endurance.

Q9. What role does art play in the lives of Joe and Delia Larrabee?

[5 Marks]

Ans: Art is both the foundation of Joe and Delia's relationship and the source of their financial struggle. They met through their shared love of art and music, which gave them a common identity and purpose. However, art is also what they must sacrifice to survive. Joe compromises his fine art for commercial painting; Delia cannot teach music professionally as she hoped. Art thus functions as a symbol of their dreams—precious but impractical. Yet the story ultimately suggests that their love for each other is itself a form of art: creative, sacrificial, and beautiful in its own way.

Part III — Long Answer Questions (10 Marks Each)

Q10. Explore the role of sacrifice and the social-economic context in 'A Service of Love'. Bring out the significance of the title.

[10 Marks]

Ans: O. Henry's 'A Service of Love' is fundamentally a story about sacrifice as the highest expression of love, set against the harsh economic realities of artistic life in New York City. The social-economic context is crucial: Joe and Delia are young artists trying to survive in a city where artistic talent rarely pays immediate dividends. Their poverty is not a background detail—it is the engine of the plot. It is poverty that forces them to abandon their dreams, take up undignified work, and construct elaborate lies to preserve each other's dignity. Sacrifice pervades every aspect of the story. Joe sacrifices his identity as a painter to become a commercial artist. Delia sacrifices her musical aspirations to become a laundress. Both sacrifice honesty—they lie to each other—but this deception is itself a sacrifice, born of love rather than selfishness. They give up the truth to protect their partner from the pain of knowing. The irony O. Henry employs is characteristic and masterful: the lies they tell are more loving than many truths. When the truth is revealed, their love not only survives but is deepened, because each understands that the other's deception was a form of devotion. The title 'A Service of Love' captures this beautifully. 'Service' suggests labour, duty, and selflessness—love expressed not in words or grand gestures, but in daily, unglamorous acts. The word 'service' also carries a sense of devotion, as in religious service, elevating their mutual sacrifice to something almost sacred. The story thus argues that love at its most profound is not a feeling but an action—a continuous, costly service offered freely, without expectation of reward.

LESSON 6 — MUMBAI'S MODELS OF SERVICE EXCELLENCE

Article by Stefan Thomke | Focus: Dabbawalas

Part I — Short Answer Questions (1 Mark Each)

Q1. When did the dabbawalas start their service in Mumbai?

[1 Mark]

Ans: The dabbawalas began their service in 1890.

Q2. How many dabbawalas are currently operating?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Approximately 5,000 dabbawalas are currently operating.

Q3. Do dabbawalas come from a literate background?

[1 Mark]

Ans: No, most dabbawalas come from a semi-literate background.

Q4. What are the four pillars of the Mumbai dabbawala system?

[1 Mark]

Ans: The four pillars are: Simplicity, Precision, Consistency, and Reliability.

Q5. What is 'takt time'?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Takt time refers to the time taken to complete one cycle of delivery, ensuring timely arrival of dabbas.

Q6. Name two prominent personalities who have visited the dabbawalas.

[1 Mark]

Ans: Prince Charles and Richard Branson have visited the dabbawalas.

Q7. What is the simple goal of the dabbawalas?

[1 Mark]

Ans: To deliver fresh, home-cooked food to customers on time, every time, with near-zero errors.

Part II — Medium Answer Questions (5 Marks Each)

Q8. What lessons can global businesses learn from the Mumbai dabbawala system?

[5 Marks]

Ans: The dabbawala system offers several powerful lessons. First, simplicity over technology: their near-perfect delivery record is achieved through a simple colour-coded system, not digital tracking. Second, empowerment: every dabbawala is also a co-owner, which creates deep personal investment in the system's success. Third, discipline and consistency: the same reliable process is followed every day without exception. Fourth, efficiency through teamwork: complex tasks are broken into precise, manageable steps shared across a team. Fifth, customer focus: the goal is always to deliver fresh food on time—nothing else matters. These principles are universally applicable, regardless of industry or

scale.

Q9. How does Thomke's article demonstrate that efficiency can be achieved under constraints?

[5 Marks]

Ans: Thomke's central argument is that Mumbai's service models—especially the dabbawalas—prove that extraordinary efficiency does not require advanced technology or unlimited resources. The dabbawalas operate in one of the world's most congested cities using bicycles, trains, and a colour-coded sorting system. Despite handling over 200,000 lunch boxes daily, their error rate is famously near zero (often cited as 1 in 6 million deliveries). Their success comes from disciplined processes, deep local knowledge, strong community bonds, and a flat organisational structure. Thomke shows that constraints—financial, technological, infrastructural—can be turned into strengths when organisations focus on what truly matters: reliability, consistency, and customer trust.

Part III — Long Answer Questions (10 Marks Each)

Q10. Write a detailed analysis of the Mumbai dabbawala system as a model of service excellence, covering its history, operations, principles, and global relevance.

[10 Marks]

Ans: The Mumbai dabbawala system is one of the world's most remarkable examples of operational excellence, and Stefan Thomke's article examines it as a model that transcends cultural and geographical boundaries. Historically, the service began in 1890 when Mahadeo Havaji Bachche started a lunch delivery service for British colonial officers who preferred home-cooked food. Today, approximately 5,000 dabbawalas deliver over 200,000 lunch boxes daily across Mumbai with an error rate so low that it has been studied by Harvard Business School and praised by organisations worldwide. Operationally, the system works through a precise relay: a dabbawala collects a lunch box (dabba) from a customer's home in the morning, travels by bicycle and local train, sorts boxes at transit points using a colour and symbol coding system (designed for semi-literate workers), and delivers them to workplaces by lunchtime—then reverses the process in the afternoon. This entire complex operation is managed without computers, smartphones, or GPS. The four pillars—Simplicity, Precision, Consistency, and Reliability—guide every aspect of operations. The concept of 'takt time' (the regulated cycle time for each delivery leg) ensures synchronisation across the entire network. Organisationally, the dabbawalas operate as a cooperative: each worker is also a co-owner, receiving equal pay and sharing profits. This flat structure eliminates bureaucracy and aligns individual incentives with collective success. The global relevance of the dabbawala model lies in its lessons for any organisation. It demonstrates that low-tech, people-centred systems can outperform high-tech alternatives. It shows that empowerment, discipline, and community can create extraordinary reliability. And it proves that excellent service is ultimately about one thing: consistently meeting the customer's need, every single day, without fail.

LESSON 7 — GENDER EQUALITY IS YOUR ISSUE TOO

Speech by Emma Watson (HeForShe Campaign, UN, 2014)

Part I — Short Answer Questions (1 Mark Each)

Q1. What campaign did Emma Watson launch through her UN speech?

[1 Mark]

Ans: She launched the HeForShe campaign, inviting men and boys to join the feminist movement.

Q2. How does Watson define feminism in her speech?

[1 Mark]

Ans: She defines feminism as the belief in the social, political, and economic equality of the sexes—not a word for man-hating.

Q3. Why does Watson address men specifically in her speech?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Because gender equality affects everyone, and men's involvement is essential for achieving it.

Q4. At what age did Watson first experience gender-based stereotyping?

[1 Mark]

Ans: She experienced it as young as age 8, when she was labelled 'bossy' for traits that would have been praised in boys.

Q5. What is the central argument of Watson's speech?

[1 Mark]

Ans: That gender equality is not a women's issue but a human issue, and men must be part of the solution.

Part II — Medium Answer Questions (5 Marks Each)

Q6. Why does Emma Watson believe gender equality benefits men as well as women?

[5 Marks]

Ans: Watson argues that rigid gender stereotypes harm men just as they harm women. Men are told they must be strong, unemotional, and dominant—and those who do not conform face stigma. Men suffer higher rates of suicide in many countries partly because they are not permitted to express vulnerability. Boys are told they cannot be sensitive, artistic, or nurturing without compromising their masculinity. Watson argues that by liberating women from the expectation of passivity, we simultaneously liberate men from the expectation of emotional suppression. True gender equality, she contends, creates a world where both men and women can be their full, authentic selves.

Q7. Discuss the significance of the HeForShe campaign and Emma Watson's rhetorical strategies.

[5 Marks]

Ans: The HeForShe campaign is significant because it shifts the framing of feminism from a movement by women for women to a universal human rights cause. Watson's rhetorical strategies are carefully

chosen. She uses personal anecdotes to create emotional connection and credibility. She directly addresses men, making them feel included rather than accused. She redefines feminism clearly and accessibly, removing the stigma many associate with the word. She uses inclusive language ('we', 'us', 'our') to build solidarity. Her tone is measured and inviting rather than combative, which makes her message harder to dismiss. Together, these strategies make the speech a model of persuasive, purposeful communication.

Part III — Long Answer Questions (10 Marks Each)

Q8. Write a detailed analysis of Emma Watson's speech 'Gender Equality Is Your Issue Too', examining its themes, arguments, and significance.

[10 Marks]

Ans: Emma Watson's 2014 UN speech is one of the most impactful feminist addresses of the 21st century, remarkable for its clarity, inclusivity, and strategic reframing of gender equality as a universal human concern. Thematically, the speech addresses several interconnected issues. The first is the misunderstanding of feminism: Watson confronts the negative associations many people have with the word 'feminist', clarifying that feminism simply means believing in the equality of men and women. By offering this clear definition early, she removes the ideological barrier that prevents many from engaging with the movement. The second theme is the universality of gender inequality's harm. Watson argues persuasively that patriarchy damages men as well as women—men are trapped by expectations of toughness and emotional stoicism that lead to isolation and mental health crises. This is a crucial rhetorical move: it makes the case for gender equality relevant to every member of the audience. The third theme is the urgency of action. Watson does not merely describe the problem; she calls for immediate, concrete engagement through the HeForShe campaign, inviting men and boys to become advocates for gender equality. Her arguments are supported by personal experience and global statistics, creating a blend of emotional appeal (pathos) and factual grounding (logos). Her own authority as a UN Women Goodwill Ambassador and a successful actress lends credibility (ethos) to her words. The speech's significance lies in its timing and reach. At a moment when the word 'feminist' was increasingly being rejected even by women who believed in equality, Watson reclaimed and rehabilitated it. She demonstrated that gender equality is not about female supremacy or male blame, but about shared liberation. Her speech sparked global conversation and mobilised millions to commit to the HeForShe campaign. As a text for study, it exemplifies how personal conviction, rhetorical skill, and a well-chosen platform can combine to shift cultural discourse.

SECTION B — LANGUAGE COMPONENTS

LANGUAGE TOPIC 1 — READING COMPREHENSION

Page 71 | Passages 1–7

Key Passage Topics & Important Questions

Q1. [Passage 1 — Digital Banking] What are the two major benefits of digital banking?

[1 Mark]

Ans: 1. Faster and more convenient transactions. 2. Increased accessibility for a wider range of people, including those in remote areas.

Q2. [Passage 1] What challenges does the financial sector face due to digital banking?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Escalated cybersecurity threats such as malware, fraud, data breaches, data leakage, and data compromise.

Q3. [Passage 1] How has employment in banking changed due to digital banking?

[2 Marks]

Ans: Roles in customer service have shifted towards technology-driven support. There is higher demand for professionals skilled in data analytics, cybersecurity, and software development.

Q4. [Passage 2 — Microfinance] What is the primary purpose of microfinance?

[1 Mark]

Ans: To offer small loans to people who do not have access to traditional banking services, enabling them to start small-scale businesses and improve their quality of life.

Q5. [Passage 2] What are the potential downsides of microfinance?

[2 Marks]

Ans: High interest rates, stringent repayment schedules, and the risk of falling into deeper debt if ventures fail or do not generate sufficient income.

Q6. [Passage 2] What factors are essential for the success of microfinance?

[2 Marks]

Ans: Effective management of microfinance institutions, financial literacy and education for borrowers, and supportive government regulations.

Q7. [Passage 3 — Reading] According to the passage, what does writing do to a man's character?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Writing makes a man an exact man—precise, careful, and thorough in his thinking.

Q8. [Passage 3] What is the real object of reading according to the passage?

[1 Mark]

Ans: To understand the author's views and their application in day-to-day life—to weigh, consider, and internalize ideas.

Q9. [Passage 4 — Women's Health] What was the main cause of poor health conditions for women in India?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Frequent foreign invasions forced people to congregate in towns in compact, unsanitary conditions, leading to poor health among women.

Q10. [General Comprehension Tip] How should you approach inference-based questions?

[Strategy]

Ans: Read the passage carefully, identify the context of the question, look for clues within surrounding sentences, and frame your answer using evidence from the text. Never add information not present in the passage.

LANGUAGE TOPIC 2 — VOCABULARY

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Important Vocabulary Questions

Q1. What does the word 'confute' mean (Passage 3)?

[1 Mark]

Ans: To disapprove or prove wrong; to refute an argument.

Q2. What does 'congregate' mean (Passage 4)?

[1 Mark]

Ans: To assemble or gather together in a group.

Q3. What word is nearly opposite in meaning to 'contend'?

[1 Mark]

Ans: 'Yield' — to give up or surrender, as opposed to contending (competing or arguing).

Q4. What is the meaning of 'confer' as used in the reading passages?

[1 Mark]

Ans: To deliberate or discuss; to consult with others.

Q5. Fill in the blank: Digital banking has _____ cybersecurity threats. (escalated/reduced/eliminated)

[1 Mark]

Ans: Escalated — digital banking has escalated cybersecurity threats.

Q6. What is an antonym for 'confine'?

[1 Mark]

Ans: To keep out or release — the opposite of confine (to restrict or keep in).

Q7. Explain the vocabulary strategy: word in context.

[Study Tip]

Ans: When you encounter an unfamiliar word, look at surrounding words and sentences for clues about meaning. Note whether the sentence is positive or negative in tone, what subject or action the word relates to, and whether you can substitute a known word that fits the context equally well.

LANGUAGE TOPIC 3 — CONCORD (Subject-Verb Agreement)

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Rules and Important Questions

Q1. What is concord (subject-verb agreement)?

[Definition]

Ans: Concord is the grammatical rule that the verb in a sentence must agree with its subject in number (singular/plural) and person (first/second/third).

Q2. Rule 1: Singular subjects take singular verbs. Give an example.

[1 Mark]

Ans: Correct: 'The student studies every day.' / Incorrect: 'The student study every day.' A singular subject (the student) takes a singular verb (studies).

Q3. Rule 2: When two subjects are joined by 'and', what verb is used?

[1 Mark]

Ans: A plural verb is used. Example: 'Ram and Shyam are friends.' (Both Ram and Shyam together = plural subject → plural verb 'are'.)

Q4. Rule 3: When subjects are joined by 'or' / 'nor', which rule applies?

[2 Marks]

Ans: The verb agrees with the subject nearest to it. Example: 'Neither the teacher nor the students were present.' (Nearest subject: students → plural verb 'were'.)

Q5. Rule 4: Collective nouns — singular or plural?

[2 Marks]

Ans: Collective nouns (team, committee, jury, family) take a singular verb when acting as a unit. Example: 'The committee has decided.' If members act individually: 'The committee are divided in opinion.'

Q6. Rule 5: Indefinite pronouns — are they singular or plural?

[1 Mark]

Ans: Pronouns like everyone, everybody, someone, nobody, each, either, neither take singular verbs. Example: 'Everyone is invited.' 'Neither of them is correct.'

Q7. Correct the sentence: 'The news are shocking.'

[1 Mark]

Ans: Correct: 'The news IS shocking.' — 'News' appears plural but is an uncountable singular noun, so it takes a singular verb.

Q8. Correct the sentence: 'Mathematics are a difficult subject.'

[1 Mark]

Ans: Correct: 'Mathematics IS a difficult subject.' — Subjects ending in -ics (mathematics, physics, economics) are treated as singular.

Q9. Rule: 'A number of' vs 'The number of' — which takes plural and which takes singular?

[2 Marks]

Ans: 'A number of' + plural noun → plural verb: 'A number of students ARE absent.' | 'The number of' + plural noun → singular verb: 'The number of students IS increasing.'

Q10. Correct the sentence: 'Each of the boys have done their homework.'

[1 Mark]

Ans: Correct: 'Each of the boys HAS done his homework.' — 'Each' is singular and takes a singular verb.

LANGUAGE TOPIC 4 — REPORTED SPEECH (Indirect Speech)

Page 99

Rules and Important Questions

Q1. What is Reported (Indirect) Speech?

[Definition]

Ans: Reported speech is the method of conveying what someone said without using their exact words. It involves changing pronouns, tense, and time expressions to fit the reporting context.

Q2. What are the tense changes when converting Direct to Indirect Speech?

[Key Rule]

Ans: Present Simple → Past Simple | Present Continuous → Past Continuous | Present Perfect → Past Perfect | Past Simple → Past Perfect | Will → Would | Can → Could | May → Might | Must → Had to

Q3. Change to Indirect Speech: The child said, 'I am hungry.'

[1 Mark]

Ans: The child said that he/she was hungry. (Present 'am' → Past 'was'; pronoun 'I' → 'he/she')

Q4. Change to Indirect Speech: She said, 'I will come tomorrow.'

[1 Mark]

Ans: She said that she would come the next day. ('will' → 'would'; 'tomorrow' → 'the next day')

Q5. Change to Indirect Speech: He said, 'I have finished my work.'

[1 Mark]

Ans: He said that he had finished his work. (Present Perfect 'have finished' → Past Perfect 'had finished')

Q6. Change to Indirect Speech: The teacher said, 'Study hard for the exam.'

[1 Mark]

Ans: The teacher advised/told the students to study hard for the exam. (Commands use 'told/asked/advised + infinitive'; no 'that')

Q7. Change to Indirect Speech: She asked, 'Are you coming to the party?'

[1 Mark]

Ans: She asked whether/if I was coming to the party. (Yes/No questions use 'whether/if'; verb form changes to past)

Q8. Change to Indirect Speech: He asked, 'Where do you live?'

[1 Mark]

Ans: He asked me where I lived. (Wh-questions use the question word as connector; word order becomes statement order)

Q9. What are the key time expression changes in Reported Speech?

[Key Rule]

Ans: now → then | today → that day | yesterday → the previous day / the day before | tomorrow → the next day / the following day | last week → the previous week | here → there | this → that | these → those

Q10. Change to Direct Speech: He said that he had been waiting for an hour.

[1 Mark]

Ans: He said, "I have been waiting for an hour." (Past Perfect → Present Perfect; 'he' → 'I')

Q11. Change to Direct Speech: She told me that she would call me the next day.

[1 Mark]

Ans: She said to me, "I will call you tomorrow." ('would' → 'will'; 'the next day' → 'tomorrow')

LANGUAGE TOPIC 5 — DATA INTERPRETATION SKILLS

Page 110 | Charts, Graphs & Tables

Key Vocabulary for Data Interpretation

Term	Meaning	Example Sentence
Increased / Rose	Went up	Sales increased in July.
Decreased / Fell / Dropped	Went down	Profits dropped markedly in Q3.
Fluctuated	Went up and down irregularly	Prices fluctuated throughout the year.
Remained steady / stable	Did not change	Production remained stable in March.
Reached a peak	Hit the highest point	Revenue reached a peak in December.
Reached a low / trough	Hit the lowest point	Sales reached a low in February.
Gradual / Steady	Slow and consistent change	There was a gradual increase.
Sharp / Dramatic / Steep	Fast or large change	There was a sharp drop in output.
Slight / Marginal	Very small change	A slight rise was seen in June.

Important Questions

Q1. What language is used to describe an upward trend in a chart?

[2 Marks]

Ans: Use: increased, rose, went up, grew, climbed. For speed: gradually, sharply, steadily, dramatically.
Example: 'Sales rose dramatically in the second quarter.'

Q2. How do you describe a downward trend?

[2 Marks]

Ans: Use: decreased, fell, dropped, declined, went down. Add adverbs for degree: slightly, markedly, sharply. Example: 'Production fell markedly between April and June.'

Q3. What is the difference between a bar chart and a line graph?

[2 Marks]

Ans: A bar chart uses rectangular bars to compare values across categories (e.g., monthly sales of different products). A line graph uses connected points to show changes or trends over time (e.g., temperature changes across a year).

Q4. How do you compare two trends in a graph?

[3 Marks]

Ans: Use comparative language: 'Unit Q shows a very similar trend to Unit S.' | 'Sales were higher than/lower than production throughout the period.' | 'While X increased, Y fluctuated.' | 'X was more than double/triple the value of Y.'

Q5. If a bar chart shows Unit Q contributes less than Unit S in June, July, and August, how would you write this?

[2 Marks]

Ans: Unit Q contributes less than Unit S in June, July, and August. Alternatively: 'Throughout the summer months (June–August), Unit S consistently outperformed Unit Q in contribution.'

Q6. How do you describe a table showing data across months?

[3 Marks]

Ans: Identify the highest and lowest values first. Then describe the overall trend (rising, falling, fluctuating). Compare columns/rows where relevant. Example: 'The data shows a continuous increase from January to April, followed by a sharp decline in May, reaching the lowest point in June.'

LANGUAGE TOPIC 6 — PARAGRAPH WRITING

Page 123 | All 4 Types | 100–150 Words

Type 1 — Expository Paragraph (Explain or Inform)

Q1. What is an expository paragraph? Give its structure.

[Definition]

Ans: An expository paragraph explains a topic clearly and objectively. Structure: (1) Topic Sentence — states the main idea. (2) Supporting sentences — provide facts, examples, or explanations. (3) Concluding sentence — summarises or reinforces the point. It is written in third person and uses logical connectors like: firstly, furthermore, in addition, therefore, as a result.

Sample: The Importance of the Internet in Education

The internet has transformed education by making learning accessible to all. Students can access millions of online resources, research papers, video lectures, and interactive platforms from anywhere in the world. E-learning portals such as Coursera and Khan Academy offer quality education at little or no cost, bridging the gap between privileged and underprivileged learners. Furthermore, the internet enables collaborative learning through discussion forums and virtual classrooms, allowing students across different geographies to learn together. Teachers can use multimedia tools to make lessons more engaging and effective. However, responsible use is essential; excessive screen time and access to unreliable information are genuine challenges. Overall, when used wisely, the internet is a powerful tool that enhances the quality, reach, and flexibility of education.

Type 2 — Narrative Paragraph (Tell a Story or Personal Experience)

Q2. What is a narrative paragraph? Give its structure.

[Definition]

Ans: A narrative paragraph tells a story or recounts a personal experience. It is written in first person (I, we) and past tense. Structure: (1) Setting the scene — when, where, who. (2) Events in sequence — what happened. (3) Climax/turning point. (4) Reflection or outcome. Use time connectors: first, then, suddenly, after that, finally.

Sample: A Visit to a New Place That Fascinated Me

Last summer, I visited Mysore for the first time, and the experience left a lasting impression on me. As our car entered the city, I was immediately struck by its wide, clean streets and the majestic Mysore Palace gleaming in the morning sunlight. We explored the palace's magnificent interiors, adorned with stained glass, carved wooden doors, and exquisite paintings. The most unforgettable moment was watching the palace illuminated by thousands of bulbs in the evening—a sight of breathtaking beauty. We also visited the Chamundi Hill temple and the vibrant Devaraja Market, where the fragrance of jasmine and incense filled the air. I returned home with a heart full of memories and a deep appreciation for Karnataka's rich cultural heritage. It was truly a journey that broadened my perspective.

Type 3 — Descriptive Paragraph (Describe Using Sensory Details)

Q3. What is a descriptive paragraph? Give its structure.

[Definition]

Ans: A descriptive paragraph uses vivid sensory details (sight, sound, smell, taste, touch) to paint a picture of a person, place, object, or event. Structure: (1) General impression — overview. (2) Specific details — use all five senses. (3) Mood/feeling — the emotion the subject evokes. Use strong adjectives and figurative language.

Sample: A Busy Marketplace

The marketplace was a riot of colour, sound, and scent that overwhelmed the senses pleasantly. Rows of stalls overflowed with fresh vegetables, glittering bangles, and fragrant spices piled into vivid orange and red mountains. Vendors called out their wares in cheerful, competing voices, while the smell of frying snacks drifted through the crowd. Shoppers moved in a colourful stream—women in bright sarees, children clutching their mothers' hands, merchants weighing goods with swift expertise. The sound of bargaining, laughter, and distant temple bells mingled in the warm afternoon air. Despite the chaos, there was an underlying rhythm and energy, as though the marketplace had a pulse of its own. It was a living, breathing portrait of community life.

Type 4 — Persuasive Paragraph (Convince or Argue a Point)

Q4. What is a persuasive paragraph? Give its structure.

[Definition]

Ans: A persuasive paragraph argues for a point of view and aims to convince the reader. Structure: (1) Clear position statement. (2) Reasons/evidence to support the position. (3) Address counter-arguments briefly. (4) Strong concluding statement. Use persuasive language: clearly, undoubtedly, it is essential that, evidence shows, therefore.

Sample: Physical Education Should Be Compulsory in Schools

Physical education should be made compulsory in all schools, as it is essential for students' overall well-being. In an age dominated by screens and sedentary habits, regular physical activity is more critical than ever. Studies clearly demonstrate that students who exercise regularly show improved concentration, better academic performance, and lower rates of anxiety and depression. Physical education also teaches vital life skills such as teamwork, discipline, and resilience—qualities that no textbook can fully impart. Critics may argue that academic subjects deserve more time, but a healthy body and mind are prerequisites for effective learning. Schools that invest in physical education are investing in the long-term health, happiness, and productivity of their students. Therefore, making physical education compulsory is not merely a health policy—it is an educational imperative.

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